

Multidimensional Security Analysis

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Recent developments in Bougainville have raised tensions between the governments of Papua New Guinea (PNG) and the Autonomous Region of Bougainville (ARB) on the issue of Bougainville's independence. After President Ishmael Toroama of the Autonomous Bougainville Government (ABG) implied that the ABG would unilaterally secede from PNG if current mediation talks do not offer clarity on Bougainville's independence, Prime Minister James Marape of PNG publicly opposed the idea of granting Bougainville its independence (UN SC, 2025). These comments from both parties highlight the fragile relationship between them, raising concerns that a peaceful resolution might not be reached at the Burnham Camp mediation talks. The ABG's interest lies in obtaining its sovereignty, which would allow it to provide its residents with solutions to the many problems enhanced by the 1988 civil war. In line with this goal, President Toroama has expressed interest in reopening the Panguna mine—estimated to have more than \$60 million USD in natural reserves of copper and gold—for this purpose (Jorari, 2022). PNG's government has made it clear that it will not agree to solutions that threaten its development, implying that for any solution to be reached, a part of the profits from the mine must be destined to PNG (UN SC, 2025). The PNG central government has established that the development of their territory must come before the interests of any party, opening the door to possible violent reprisal from the military on the population of Bougainville. Given the history of violent conflict between PNG and Bougainville secessionists, it is imperative for a solution to be reached in the near future to avoid further harm to the populations of Bougainville and PNG.

Earlier this week, Prime Minister James Marape decided to mobilize a portion of Papua New Guinea's military forces in preparation for a possible deployment to Bougainville (UNSC,

2025). In response to the Prime Minister's action, Bougainville President Ishmael Toroama reaffirmed the ABG's commitment to independence, with some sources inferring that the President would make use of force if necessary (UNSC, 2025). Since this sequence of events threatens the peaceful negotiations between both parties, the United Nations Security Council should act to preserve international peace & security—its primary responsibility per Article 24 (1) of the UN Charter (Mani & Ponzio, 2018). There exist multiple options for the UN SC to consider to prevent armed conflict in this region of the world, including preventive diplomacy, sanctions, peacekeeping and peace enforcement. The UN SC should consider involvement in this region to avoid a second armed conflict to break out in Bougainville, where the effects of the Bougainville Civil War are still felt every day. During the ten year-long conflict, researchers have estimated the total number of casualties to be between 12,000-20,000, additionally, 15,000-20,000 people fled from Bougainville during the conflict, while 67,300 were internally displaced by it (Tierney et al. 2016). The PNG military also committed severe human rights violations during the conflict, including the holding of residents living close to the area of the Panguna mine in detention camps where torture, rape and extrajudicial assassinations took place (Adams & Kerwin 2020). Consequently, as derived by the UN Charter, it is the responsibility of the SC to ensure compliance with human rights by all member states—including Papua New Guinea. These responsibilities, conferred by the UN member states upon the SC, urge the council to act to fulfill its duties of maintaining peace in Papua New Guinea.

In consideration of the goals and mission of the Security Council, the SC must consider the establishment of a peacebuilding mission in Bougainville to ensure the safety and security of all citizens of this region. This peacebuilding mission would succeed in controlling the situation

surrounding Bougainville's secession through its focus in sustainable development and peace efforts. The ABG's current inability to be fiscally self-reliant, affects the local government's ability to provide basic services such as electricity and healthcare to Bougainville's residents (Ray, 2025). The peacebuilding mission would then be tasked with assisting local authorities in developing a sustainable economy by improving the stability of governance, ensuring that the human rights of Bougainville's residents are protected while promoting sustainable economic activities. The development of these sustainable practices would also open the way for better dialogue between the ABG and the PNG central government on the issue of the Panguna mine's ownership. The control over the Panguna mine has been at the forefront of conversations between Prime Minister Marape's government and the ABG, with sources speculating that any discussion of Bougainville's independence would have to guarantee a part of the profits be destined for PNG (UNSC, 2025). By aiding the development of stable governance in Bougainville, this mission will encourage a faster re-opening of the Panguna mine, incentivising the PNG central government and the ABG to consent in the deployment of this peacekeeping mission. Relieving the pressure on this central topic would allow the ABG to have a wider range of negotiation, facilitating the ability for the ABG to reach a peaceful resolution to the matter of the Panguna mine with PNG's government. This mission's emphasis on developing stable governance would ensure long term economic growth, guaranteeing reduced risk of hostilities in the long run (Paris, 2018). A Disarmament Demilitarization Reinsertion and Reintegration (DDRR) initiative would have to also be implemented addressing the circumstances of the different groups of people that own stolen weapons from the disposal exercise at the end of the Bougainville Civil War (Stolen Weapons, 2024). As a consequence of the peacebuilding initiative,

it is possible that the demand for Bougainville's economic activities might not exist within the international community. This is currently not a major concern, given the location of Bougainville in the Pacific, it has attracted interest from regional actors wishing to influence the development of this island, ensuring the long-term options available to Bougainville's development (Ray, 2025).

Peace enforcement remains a less desirable option when compared to peacebuilding since it would fail to address the root causes of the tensions in Bougainville. This method's focus on using coercive force to avoid threats to peace (i.e. lack of violence), would only serve to further the issues threatening the livelihoods of Bougainville's residents. Given that PNG holds a stronger position to negotiate from, peace enforcement would allow for PNG's government to force the ABG into an unfavorable agreement. In turn this would require future UN SC efforts to fix, since the hypothetical mission would have played a role in eliminating the ABG's threat of force to serve as a deterrent from PNG using dishonest negotiation tactics.

In accordance with the goals and mission of the Security Council, the SC must consider applying a broad human security approach to properly address the threats to Bougainville's and PNG's residents to prevent further harm to human life in the region. This approach would—within the Commission of Human Security's definition of human security—empower the SC to protect the region's residents from all critical and pervasive threats they face, while building on their strengths to build systems that support their lives (Oberleitner, 2009). In the context of the recent developments, this means establishing realistic pathways to addressing the needs of population of Bougainville (development of health care and other basic necessities); recognizing all possible threats to the human integrity of the population (the

possible deployment of PNG military forces in Bougainville, environmental degradation, lack of basic services and the potential armed conflict); and allowing the population of Bougainville to freely determine what their needs are. This framework allows the SC to pursue solutions that account for the needs of Bougainville, while still acknowledging the ramifications of their secession on the continued development of PNG. The framework would support solutions that aim to improve the health of the island's residents and address the environmental crisis they face by recognizing the interconnectedness of these threats, incentivizing cooperation among all involved actors, and protecting Bougainville's residents while empowering them to make their own decisions. To meet this framework's understanding, it is imperative that the SC ensures that democratic resolution to the issue of Bougainville's independence is achieved. After having voted 98 percent in favor of independence, it is clear that Bougainville residents seek to be independent from PNG (Jorari, 2022). Thus, it is imperative that the Security Council's actions protect the population's need for independence. Additionally, the connection between all of these perceived threats has to be addressed. The health of many people in Bougainville is affected as a consequence of the improper disposal of waste from the Panguna mine, thus, even if the health care infrastructure is supported by the peace keeping operation, the success of this action will be seriously impacted by the waste being left unattended.

Bougainville is still suffering the environmental impact of the improper management of residuals from the Panguna mine, with an estimated 90 percent of residents who live near waste dumping zones having no access to safe and clean drinking water (Swanston & Gunga 2023). Additionally, between 1992-1998—during the initial armed conflict in Bougainville—it has been estimated that 100,000 residents of central and southern Bougainville had no access to

doctors (Tierney et al. 2016). As a result of the war, studies have estimated that 37.8% of women and 32% of men present heightened symptoms of depression, however, as of 2016, there is only one mental-health nurse available to provide care to the 254,000 residents of the island (Jewkes et al. 2017) & (Tierney et al. 2016). Under the framework of human security, the presence of a threat of mental and physical illnesses is a pervasive threat to the health security of individuals (Ostergard & Griffin, 2018). President Toroama of the ABG has argued recently that Bougainville's governance infrastructure remains underdeveloped due to the actions of the PNG central government (UN SC, 2025). Thus, the UN SC must address these concerns to prevent further escalation of tensions between the ABG and PNG's central government to maintain international peace.

The mine's waste disposal has been identified as one of the main causes for the outbreak of violence in Bougainville in 1988, since improper waste disposal resulted in the destruction of the Jaba River valley's forests, loss of water and fish resources in the Kawerong and Jaba rivers and the loss of nearby agricultural fields (Adams & Kerwin, 2020). These unsafe mining activities undermined the stability of Bougainville's residents, resulting in grave consequences to their livelihoods and human security. Consequently, landowners decided to protest the harm done by Bougainville Copper Limited—the company in charge of the Panguna mine—however, their demands were not met by BCL (Adams & Kerwin, 2020). This decision by BCL to not implement proper environmental controls and pay the 10 billion PNG Kinas demanded as compensation for the damage, prompted the Panguna Landowners Association (PLA) to take actions to sabotage the operations of the Panguna mine (Adams & Kerwin, 2020). After being allegedly pressured by BCL to protect the mine, the PNG central government's

violent repression of the PLA rebellion caused the violence to expand to all of Bougainville, making secession from PNG a key goal of the rebellion (Allen, 2020). Recent case studies in Asia, have shown that governance stability affects the capacity of poor rural communities to build sustainable livelihoods (Peras et al. 2021). Expanding this understanding to the Oceanian islands of Bougainville would benefit solutions to the human security threats of Bougainville's residents, given that the protection and rehabilitation of the Kaweron and Jaba rivers is a central concern to these communities.

The human security of PNG's citizens benefits from the protection of sustainable livelihoods in Bougainville. If the UN SC supports the implementation of an appropriate environmental response, the tensions over the Panguna mine would cease, and PNG's economy would benefit by the faster reopening of mine activities if a deal is reached between the governmental actors. Additionally, solving the immediate threats caused by the loss of livelihoods in Bougainville lowers the threat of violent conflict, eliminating a possible threat to the lives of Bougainville and PNG residents.

Many similarities appear in the understanding of International security and Human security regarding the tensions between PNG and Bougainville. Both frameworks comprehend that to achieve a peaceful resolution, the governance structure of Bougainville must be supported by the United Nations Security Council. If the SC decided to approve the establishment of a peacekeeping mission with peacebuilding capabilities, this mission would assist in efforts to combat the challenges faced in the provision of basic services to the population of Bougainville. Under the human security approach, this mission would also support efforts to properly address the contamination of Bougainville's rivers to ensure that

communities can have more opportunities to develop sustainable livelihoods. The interconnectedness of these threats to human integrity must remain in the forefront of any efforts by the SC, since it has been shown by the historical evidence that affectations to the environment eventually led to violent conflict. Current tensions are rising due to the unaddressed damage to the health, and livelihoods of individuals, caused by the conflict, highlighting the importance of a broad human security approach to achieve a permanent solution to hostilities. The peacebuilding initiative would have to assist in the efforts to solve the environmental damage to support sustainable development in the region.

The SC would have to also pursue solutions that respond to the concerns unique to the context of Bougainville and PNG, while ensuring that the solutions are multi-sectoral and comprehensive, bringing as many local actors as possible together to find solutions that address all threats to ensure their permanence. These aspects, if ignored, could worsen the situation as it stands. The mission's success depends on its ability to fund solutions that will address the basic needs of Bougainville's residents while ensuring that the reopening of the Panguna mine will not result in further damage to the environment. As highlighted by waste disposal consultants to BCL, waste could be stored in a conventional tailings dam, avoiding serious harm to the environment (Adams & Kerwin, 2020). Given that these solutions have been proposed before, but were never undertaken due to a lack of interest by BCL in funding proper environmental prevention tools, the UN SC could endorse a similar solution to prevent the mine from causing further damage. This oversight over waste material would then prevent additional harm to communities that live near the zones where the waste is located, and together, with

funding to stable governance structures, would better the health of these communities, as well as other communities around Bougainville.

The health care infrastructure of Bougainville would also have to receive critical support, given the variety of issues that it is not equipped to solve, such as the depression symptoms that affect around 1 in every 3 residents of Bougainville. Further training of medical professionals in the islands, or other possible mechanisms should seek the advice of World Health Organization (WHO), Doctors Without Borders, and all other possible UN institutions and NGO partners to seek immediate relief to the health security threats faced by the population of Bougainville. By emphasizing the human security aspect of this situation, the UN SC will, in line with meet its responsibility to the preservation of international peace & security per Article 24 (1) of the UN Charter (Mani & Ponzio, 2018). By enhancing the mandate of the peace keeping mission to meet the needs of the general population of Bougainville, it will also meet the recommendations made by the HIPPO panel regarding the priorities of these missions with regards to political affairs of the situation (Gowan, 2018). Then, by supporting the needs of the general population, the mission would eventually facilitate negotiations to take place between Papua New Guinea and Bougainville with regards to how the earnings from mine operations will be distributed amongst the actors. The role of the mission here should ensure that the interests of Bougainville's citizens are met, especially their overwhelming support for Bougainville's independence from PNG, as seen by the support from 98% of Bougainville's residents to the independence referendum. This ensures that they will obtain freedom from fear of repression, a core principle of human security. Finally, by connecting the mandate of the proposed peace keeping mission, and its peace building capabilities to the framework of human security, the UN

SC will be able to realistically, and responsively, prevent violence from erupting in this region of the world.